

Mount Rushmore

A project aimed at attracting tourists to South Dakota in the 1920s that now draws 3 million people a year to admire the faces of four American presidents



The huge sculptures of Mount Rushmore in the Black Hills of South Dakota were conceived to promote tourism. Doane Robinson, a local historian who read about plans for the massive Confederate Memorial on Stone Mountain in Georgia, decided in 1923 to create a similar site to attract visitors to South Dakota.

Sculpting the mountain

The artist Gutzon Borglum suggested Mount Rushmore as a possible site. In 1929, President Calvin Coolidge signed a bill creating a commission to oversee the project. Construction began in 1927, and the four faces, each 60 ft (18 m) high, were completed between 1930 and 1939. The

presidents—George Washington, Thomas Jefferson, Theodore Roosevelt, and Abraham Lincoln—were chosen for their role in founding and preserving the Union and expanding its territory.

The bulk of the mountain was carved using dynamite until only about 3–6 in (7.5–15 cm) of rock remained. The drillers and carvers then drilled small holes into the granite in a process called honeycombing. Finally, the workers evened up the granite, creating a surface as smooth as pavement. The construction was ultimately completed in 1941.

